

Going Green: The Case Against Meat

1. Introduction

I have recently decided to become vegetarian. This decision may come as strange to those who know me, and so, rather than trying to defend myself through conversation, I hope to explain my rationale behind why I have decided to do so in this article. I do not plan for this to be a long explanation with long, winding abstract arguments or anything of the sort for a simple reason: I believe that the arguments in favor of vegetarianism are simply much stronger than the arguments in favor of eating meat. I'm sure we have all had some sort of ethical inclination against the consumption of animals at some point in our lives, but given the lack of developed reasoning behind this inclination and the availability and frankly delicious taste of meat, we have largely ignored this. It is my hope, therefore, to convince you, at the very least, to reduce the quantity of meat you are consuming in your diet. If we value doing the right thing and being good people, which I hope is a reasonable thing we all should care about, then I hope this article makes it ever more obvious that we ought to cut meat from our diets.

2. Pigs and Puppies

Imagine that you are reading the news one day when you come across a local story about a man called Fred. Following reports of strange noises coming from Fred's basement, the police decide to investigate the cause of the noises; what they find is appalling. In Fred's basement, there are twenty-six small wire cages, each containing a puppy, whining, whimpering, or howling. Urine and feces cover the floor of Fred's basement, and each puppy shows signs of mutilation; some are without noses, some without tails, and some without paws. As the police interrogate Fred, he details out what he has been doing for the last few years: The puppies are kept in their cages for twenty-six weeks and aren't allowed to be out except for when Fred decides to mutilate them, never with anesthesia. At the end of the twenty-six weeks, Fred butchers the puppies while holding them upside-down and harvests their brains.

What would be your reaction to a case like Fred's? Undoubtedly, you would most likely be outraged and disgusted with Fred's actions. However, in his trial, Fred explains the rationale behind his actions and argues that he is morally blameless for them. As the trial unfolds, Fred explains that he is a great lover of chocolate and has always been for his entire life; it is his favorite food, and he would never willingly give it up. Fred explains that, a few years ago, he got into a car accident, which subsequently resulted in brain trauma that greatly diminished the enjoyment he got from eating chocolate. Dismayed by this, Fred decided to seek out world-renowned gustatory neurologists for a solution to his condition. After extensive testing, Fred learned that the accident had irreparably damaged his godiva glands, which are responsible for excreting cocoamone, the hormone responsible for the delicious taste of chocolate. Though Fred was desperate for hormone replacement therapy, to his immense disappointment, he

realized that there were no known sources of cocoamone that could be collected in order to be used. However, by pure chance, Fred discovered, in a paper by a veterinarian surgeon, that puppies, who normally do not produce any cocoamone in their brains, can be stimulated to do so through extended periods of intense stress and suffering. Though Fred grew hopeful from this discovery, he soon learned that there were no commercially available sources of puppy-derived cocoamone. However, given the possibility of a solution to his condition, Fred decided to read up on the research and develop his own homemade lab to derive cocoamone in his basement. The process, he explains, is straightforward: six months of intense suffering followed by a brutal death. The result: enough cocoamone to last Fred a week. Fred explains to the court that he is not a sadist or animal abuser and derives no pleasure from torturing the puppies. Indeed, he claims that, if there was another way to get cocoamone without torturing puppies, he would gladly employ it. However, there is not, and so Fred has resorted to his current methods. Though Fred sympathizes with those who are horrified by the pain and misery he has enacted on the puppies, he wants others to understand that human pleasure is at stake; the puppies, after all, are mere animals. Fred recognizes that his life would be just as healthy, if not more so, without chocolate in it, but he claims that is beside the point; the quality of his life would be unacceptably diminished without the experience of chocolate.

Are you satisfied with Fred's justification for his actions? Clearly, we should not be. Though it is unfortunate that Fred can no longer enjoy the taste of chocolate, in no way does that make the torture of puppies morally excuseable; no decent person would accept that it is morally permissible to enact severe suffering on puppies in order to merely enhance a gustatory experience. However, billions of animals around the world endure this suffering every year for precisely this end. The vast majority of chicken, beef, and pork consumed in the US come from intensive confinement facilities, where the animals live cramped, stressful lives and endure unanesthetized mutilations throughout their lives (for empirical evidence, I strongly recommend the documentary *Dominion*). Furthermore, it has been proven that the vast majority of people would suffer no loss of health by eliminating meat from their diets. If we are readily prepared to condemn Fred for torturing puppies to enhance his gustatory experiences, why are we not so readily prepared to condemn the millions who purchase and consume factory-raised meat?

One might notice some supposed disanalogies between Fred's behavior and our behavior. For one, Fred enacts the suffering on the puppies himself, while the average meat-consumer does not. However, it is not clear that this is a morally relevant difference at all. Consider instead that Fred was squeamish, and so he hired someone else to torture the puppies and harvest their brains at the end of the twenty-six weeks. Would we think better of Fred in this altered scenario? Clearly, we should not.

Another supposed disanalogy between us and Fred that some may propose, and one I think a lot of decent people believe in, is that, while Fred's behavior is morally repugnant, we are

crucially different in that, if we stopped purchasing and consuming meat, the suffering of animals would not change, while Fred could fully prevent the misery of the puppies if he decided to stop consuming chocolate. So, even recognizing the moral badness of raising factory animals for the sake of consumption, given the enormity of agribusiness, our purchasing habits cannot prevent the suffering of animals, and so we may as well be entitled to the taste of their flesh. This is the argument from causal impotence, and I will cover this in more detail in section four. However, for the time being, assuming that we can have no causal influence on the agribusiness industry (which I believe is certainly wrong), let us modify the Fred scenario to accompany this suggested difference and see if it can adhere to our intuitions. Imagine you, with perfectly functioning godiva receptors, are invited by a friend to eat at a fancy restaurant in Paris. While there, your friend recommends you order their famous chocolate mousse, which they serve with a cup of coffee, instructing you to drink it before eating the mousse. Upon doing so, the mousse becomes the most delicious dessert that you've ever tasted; never in your life have you experienced such rich and velvety chocolate. When you ask your friend how they made the mousse so delicious, she responds that the mousse is as ordinary as any other mousse, but the cup of coffee that you drank contains a concentrated dose of cocoamone harvested from the brains of newly slaughtered puppies in a lab next to the restaurant. Naturally, you feel horrified by this discovery and refuse to order a second mousse. Furthermore, you are shocked that your friend, who always seemed to be a decent person, would both recommend and consume the mousse while being fully aware of the suffering necessary to enable this experience. Though she agrees that it is morally condemnable to torture puppies for the sake of human pleasure, since the production of cocoamone is a massive industry in France, neither you nor your friend can save any puppies by choosing to not consume cocoamone. Hence, the puppies will suffer regardless of what you do, and as such, you might as well enjoy the mousse. If it is the case that someone who is perfectly aware of the horrifying process involved in the creation of the chocolate mousse cannot order one in a way that is morally justifiable, then it should also be the case that someone who is perfectly aware of the details of factory farming cannot purchase factory-raised meat in a way that is morally justifiable.

A more philosophical disanalogy between Fred's treatment of puppies and our treatment of animals is that the suffering of Fred's puppies is a necessary means to his enjoyment of chocolate, while the suffering of animals on factory farms is simply a by-product of the conditions as dictated by economic factors. Hence, it could be claimed that the suffering of puppies is *intended* as a means to an end, while the suffering of factory-raised animals is merely *foreseen* as a side effect of satisfying the gustatory pleasures of consumers. This distinction is central to the Doctrine of Double Effect, which claims that it is sometimes morally permissible to bring about an effect if it is merely foreseen, but not permissible if it is strictly intended. To demonstrate the merit of this doctrine, consider this slight modification of the famous trolley thought experiment. Imagine you are on the beach when suddenly a massive wave comes inward, threatening to drown you along with the others on the beach. Luckily, you have access to a

vehicle that would allow you to escape the tide with time to spare. Given this, you can go and pick up some additional people from the beach in order to save. Consider that, to your left, there is a group of five individuals, while to your right, there is only one. Given that you can only go one direction before the wave hits the coast, it seems that the correct thing you should do is to go left and save the group of five, despite allowing one person to die as a result. However, consider now that, in order to save the group of five, you must drive over and kill one individual who's buried in the sand. If you choose to dig him out, you will only save one person, thereby allowing five people to die. In the latter scenario, it seems much more morally questionable for one person to die in order to save five, though the end results are numerically identical, because you must *intend* to kill them rather than *foresee* their death. Though the Doctrine of Double Effect is controversial (with some going as far as to deny it having any moral relevance whatsoever), it is entirely irrelevant to the point I am about to make; the fact that we have such moral intuitions regarding it is enough evidence to suffice for our purposes. Even assuming that the Doctrine of Double Effect is morally relevant to the scenario at the beach, it is not at all obvious that it will be relevant to the supposed disanalogy between Fred and us. This is because, in order for us to apply the doctrine in the first place, there must be an *outweighing* good effect involved in the situation that can make an otherwise immoral effect permissible. In the beach scenario, such a good effect is obvious: the five lives being saved. However, in the case of consuming factory-raised meat, it is not clear that there is any good effect involved; we certainly should not claim that a pleasure gustatory experience is even morally relevant in this case, let alone morally beneficial. So, even if the suffering of animals is merely foreseen, we do not lose anything of moral significance by choosing to not consume meat. To further strengthen my point, consider that, one day, you notice a small child drowning in a shallow pond. If you choose not to get into the pond and save the child, you have not in any way intended for the child to die; you merely foresaw their death. However, I think that it would be abominable if one watched as a child drowned only so as to not get their clothing wet. Given that we would lose nothing of moral significance by getting our clothes wet and that the preventable death of a child is morally abhorrent, we have a moral obligation to save the drowning child. Analogously, we do not lose anything of moral significance when we decide to stop eating meat, and the suffering of animals in factory farms is morally abhorrent. Therefore, we have an obligation to stop purchasing and eating meat. And to add to this even more, consider a modification to the Fred scenario: Cocoamone can only be produced through a chemical reaction when large quantities of drain cleaner are forced down the throats of conscious, unanesthetized puppies. In this modified scenario, if Fred decides to force-feed his puppies with drain-cleaner, it will no longer be the case that Fred intends for his puppies to suffer, since their suffering is not a necessary means for the production of cocoamone. However, such suffering will nevertheless be an unavoidable side effect of the actual means to produce cocoamone, which is forcing drain cleaner down their throats. In this variation of the scenario, Fred's behavior is no less morally abominable than in the original, where he intends to cause the suffering of the puppies.

Finally, the most plausible reason for why we feel so strongly towards the actions of Fred and not towards the actions of those who consume factory-raised meat is that Fred specifically kills *puppies* rather than, say, pigs. While there is an undeniable psychological difference between the slaughtering of puppies compared to other animals in that we are much more sympathetic to puppies than to farm animals, such an attitude is culturally relativistic and hence morally irrelevant; Fred's actions would be no less wrong if he committed them in a place and time where society did not have strong emotional attachments to puppies. Perhaps instead it is the case that puppies have a higher moral status than that of farm animals given that they possess some morally relevant property that other animals do not, be it a higher degree of rationality, a more developed moral sense, or simply a higher level of loyalty. However, this approach is obviously flawed in that it is highly unlikely any of these properties have moral relevance when deciding when it is permissible to torture one species of animal and not another. Consider if Fred had gone out of his way to acquire particularly stupid, morally insensitive, and disloyal puppies in order to torture for cocaine. It is clear that even if this were the case, his behavior is still morally unacceptable. Given that I have been unable to discern any morally relevant differences between the Fred scenario and the actual case of the millions who purchase and consume factory-raised meat with full awareness of the suffering animals endure, then if morality demands of us to not torture puppies in order to enhance our gustatory experiences, it also demands that we do not support factory farming by purchasing and consuming factory-raised meat.

One might propose that there is a morally relevant gap between the moral status of producing meat and consuming it, such that the former is wrong but the latter is not, but we can bridge this gap quite easily. Consider the following line of reasoning: Consuming some product p is participating in the production of p ; production of p is wrong; it is wrong to participate in the production of wrongful things; hence, consuming p is wrong. From here, it is easy to see that meat can be substituted for product p . As I will argue later on, each individual, by consuming factory-raised meat, plays a distinct causal role in supporting the agribusiness industry. Such participation, I believe, actively enables the suffering of animals, which is a morally significant downside of a non-morally significant action. However, by choosing to not eat meat and hence not supporting the agribusiness industry, an individual will lose nothing of moral significance. Given this, we can extend the wrongness of producing meat to the wrongness of consuming it.

3. The Principle of Equality

In the previous section, I briefly covered why certain properties, such as rationality, cannot serve as the basis of one's moral status. I will develop said arguments in this section, given the notoriety they have had in non-philosophical circles when attempting to justify the superiority of humans. After presenting negative arguments against some proposals for the basis of moral status, I plan to advocate for a positive one that most coherently adheres to our

intuitions in marginal cases. In doing so, I hope to extend this proposed basis of moral status to animals.

Before we can advocate for the equal consideration of nonhuman animals, we should examine the basis on which equality for historically oppressed groups rests upon. When we make the claim that all humans are equal regardless of race, sex, religion, or whatever else, what exactly are we claiming? In other words, what is the principle of equality? It is important, I believe, to clarify what makes people equal first in order to see how, when the same principle of equality is applied to animals, we cannot justifiably argue their inferiority. To demonstrate this, we need to consider why racism and sexism are wrong. One initial response to this question is to say that one's race or sex cannot serve as a guide to their abilities, and therefore it is wrong to discriminate on such a basis. However, this assertion rests upon an empirical claim that we cannot say with confidence is true: The variation of ability between races or sexes is distributed evenly without regard to race or sex within humans. Indeed, insofar as ability is concerned, there actually do seem to be measurable differences between races and sexes when averages are taken. However, given that it is an open question of to what extent these differences are to be explained through genetic differences and to what extent they are to be explained through environmental factors, it would be precarious to rest the case against racism or sexism on the basis that these differences are to be explained purely through environmental factors, since it would force the opponent of racism to concede that racism would be in some way defensible if it were proven that differences in ability did have some genetic relationship with race. Hence, it would be a mistake to define the principle of equality in any descriptive claim of an alleged actual equality between humans, be it intelligence, strength, moral capacity, or whatever else. Equality is a moral *idea*, not an assertion of *fact*; it is to be defined as a prescriptive claim about how we *should* treat humans. There is no compelling reason to accept that any factual difference in ability between people or groups can justify any difference in the amount of consideration we give to their needs and interests.

Given that the principle of equality demands for some property to give everyone's interests equal consideration, the question now is what property can meet this requirement and whether it can be extended to animals. It is commonly held, I believe, that most people think of humans as having a superior moral status than that of animals, given that humans are equal to one another by virtue of some property and that all animals lack this property; hence, the principle of equality does not extend to said animals. What property could this be? The traditional view, dating back to Aristotle, is that what separates humans from animals is rationality. More recently, given a greater understanding of the cognitive processes of animals, philosophers have attempted to refine the rationality requirement so that one must have a level of rationality necessary for moral reasoning in order to obtain a privileged moral status. In doing so, those who hold this position can prescribe equal moral standing to all humans and avoid discrimination based on ability while simultaneously denying the same moral standing to

animals. Because humans have a higher moral standing, according to this view, their interests are also more important than those of animals.

However, whatever level of rationality required to justify the attribution of a superior moral status to humans will always either be lacking in some humans or present in some animals. Take the position that, in order to have superior moral status, one must be able to engage in moral reflection. However, this account of rationality is surely flawed since it denies a privileged moral status to those who are temporarily or permanently unable to engage in moral reflection, such as in the case of infants or the severely senile. It further denies a privileged moral status to those who never had the capacity for moral reflection, such as the severely mentally disabled. If the moral superiority of humans rests upon this account of rationality of being able to partake in moral reflection, then it excludes many humans from such a privileged class. One would be forced to accept that we have the same reasons to use cognitively deficient humans for experiments and food as we do for animals. There are two responses to these marginal cases: the first is to deny that we must attribute a different moral status to marginal humans while still maintaining that we are justified in attributing an inferior moral status to animals with the same cognitive capacities as marginal humans, while the second is to accept that marginal humans are morally inferior to other humans, but nevertheless assert that we have pragmatic reasons for treating them as if they had equal status.

Let us consider the first type of argument. There are a few lines of reasoning which defend the position that allows for marginal humans to have a privileged moral status while denying the same privileged moral status to animals. This is typically done through two moves: The first is to claim that there exists a property that has so much moral significance that its presence or absence can single-handedly determine whether an action is morally justified or morally outrageous, and the second is to assert that the presence or absence of said property in any *particular* case is morally irrelevant, and that we only need to consider whether the presence or absence of the property is *normal*. This can be done by basing the rationality requirement on potentiality, such that it is the case that all humans have the potential to engage in moral reflection, and it is only a contingent fact that some do not, while animals could never have this capability of moral reasoning. Hence, we must treat humans as if they have met the rationality requirement simply because they could have, while we can deny the same treatment to animals on the basis that they could have never met said requirement. It can also be done by appealing to the typical characteristics of species in that different species are different *types*, and that we can make decisions on this basis by recognizing that animals are indeed different types compared to humans. Given that having a certain degree of rationality is relevant to what it means to be a human, while irrelevant to any essential feature of an animal, we can extend a privileged moral status to all humans and to no animals. However, where these arguments fall is obvious. To demonstrate their failures, consider the following example: There are ten famous people in the afterlife on trial for whether they will get into heaven or if they will go to hell. At the end of the

trial, five are found guilty, while the other five are found innocent. However, out of the five that are found guilty, four are sent to an eternity of torment in hell, while one gets access to an eternity of bliss in heaven. Likewise, out of the five that were found innocent, four are given access to heaven, while the other one is sentenced to hell. When asked why this is the case, the judge responds that the normal condition of all the guilty defendants is that they are all male, while the normal condition for all the innocent defendants is that they are all female. Hence, it must be the case that we send Gandhi to hell with Adolf Hitler, Joseph Stalin, Jeffery Dahmer, and Saddam Hussein, while we send Margret Thatcher to heaven. According to this line of reasoning, the fact that Gandhi is innocent or Thatcher is guilty is irrelevant to their eternal punishment or reward, since the *particular* property of innocence or guilt is irrelevant; we must only consider the *normal* condition of innocence and guilt in males and females. But perhaps one could respond that the categorization of innocence and guilt are contingent matters based on one's personal decisions, and hence such a category is largely arbitrary; instead, we should define normalcy in terms of *natural* categories based on essences, such as that of species. However, this does not seem to provide any more explanatory power in telling us why such categorization would be morally relevant. Suppose it was established as a fact that men were, on average, better at manipulating numbers than women, and women, on average, were more empathetic than men. I hope it is uncontroversial to claim that the biological differences between men and women are just as real and natural as the differences between humans and other species. Would such differences in the normal conditions of men and women make it so that we ought to prefer an innumerate man to a woman math genius for an engineering job, or a sociopathic woman over an ultra-sensitive man for a job as a therapist? This is surely an absurd conclusion to accept, and so we must reject the same line of reasoning when applied to justify the discrimination of animals.

The second type of argument bites the bullet and accepts that cognitively deficient humans really do have an inferior moral status compared to humans with the capacity to engage in moral reasoning. However, if there is no morally relevant way to distinguish cognitively deficient humans from, say, chimpanzees who have a similar level of rationality, does this mean we could go one step further and claim that it is permissible to use cognitively deficient people for experimentation? This is not a conclusion, I think, that anyone would want to accept, so there must be some additional, non-moral reason that would block this further step. Such a reason, one may claim, is based on powerful practical or emotional considerations, and that such considerations can only be extended to non-rational human beings, thereby denying this blocking reason to be applicable to animals. Though this line of reasoning does not incorporate morally relevant differences to justify the distinction between humans and animals in treatment, it encapsulates the role of feeling and sentiment in moral thinking. However, what constitutes the role of feelings and sentiment in moral thinking is a very shaky basis upon which we can justify our differing practices surrounding cognitively deficient humans and animals given that what influences human sensibilities is a contingent matter based on empirical differences. Though it

may be the case that we feel sympathy for the cognitively deficient but not animals, in no way does this justify that we *ought* to treat the former group better or that their interests should be given more weight, since what constitutes human sympathy rests on very fragile grounds. One does not need to look deep into history to see this point being demonstrated; indeed, history is filled with examples of widespread acceptance of the systematic mistreatment of oppressed groups who did not generate sympathetic responses from others. To further this point, imagine a new type of birth defect in humans called Bovinism, which leads to a child to have severe cognitive deficiencies, green skin, and an inability to form an emotional bond with their parents. Furthermore, imagine that the degree of cognitive deficiency is of the same kind and severity as other birth defects that do not have the latter two conditions. If we were to deny a privileged moral status to such humans with Bovinism, it seems very likely that we would be at less of a risk to outrage human sensibilities compared to a denial of a privileged moral status to other, more loved humans with different birth defects. Would these contingent empirical differences between humans with Bovinism and humans with other birth defects justify us in ascribing a different moral status to them given that the only difference between them is their skin color and whether they are loved by others? Surely, the answer is no; any proposal for the basis of moral status that ascribes moral relevance to these differences is to be taken as absurd.

The mistake that the previous arguments have made in trying to deny the same moral status to animals that humans have is that they all depend on some notion of rationality to justify this denial. But why should we think that the possession of a higher degree of rationality can justify one's interests as having greater moral significance when compared to another sentient being who does not possess the same level of rationality? I would like to clarify that I do not believe rationality is entirely morally irrelevant, but I would like to question what this moral relevance amounts to. Here, it is important to draw the distinction between moral agents and moral patients. While the former group can be held morally responsible for their actions and must fulfill certain obligations, the latter group cannot. If a being lacks a degree of rationality required to engage in moral reasoning, then it cannot be a moral agent and hence can receive no moral blame or praise for their actions. When we punish a dog for doing something wrong, we are in no way expressing a moral judgment about the dog's behavior, but are instead merely trying to alter its future behavior. However, just because an entity is not a moral agent should not exclude their status as moral patients; in fact, whether one is a moral agent or not should be entirely irrelevant to their status as a moral patient. If the property of rationality dictates whether one is a moral agent or not, what property dictates whether one is a moral patient? The answer to this question, I believe, is the capacity to suffer. It is due to this capacity that a being should be given equal consideration for their interests. In doing so, we would not arbitrarily exclude from consideration any interests of any beings at all, unlike if we based the right to equal consideration on a property such as rationality. This is because the capacity to suffer is a prerequisite for having any interests at all, and it is both necessary and sufficient in this regard, for, at an absolute minimum, a being will have an interest in not suffering. On the other hand, a

property such as rationality would arbitrarily exclude the interests of several groups, including, but not limited to, animals, the cognitively deficient, young children, and very old people. This is surely an absurd conclusion. Insofar as a being has the capacity to suffer, in accordance with the principle of equality, there is no morally justifiable line of reasoning that refuses to take the suffering of animals into consideration. As long as a being is a moral patient, then the principle of equality demands that its suffering must be counted equally with the suffering of other beings. Just as we should not be racists by providing a greater emphasis to the interests of our own race in order to override the greater interests of members of another race, we too should not be *speciesists* by providing a greater emphasis to the interests of our own species in order to override the greater interests of members of another species. In consuming meat, however, we violate the principle of equality by sacrificing the most important interest of members of different species (their interest to not suffer) in order to promote the most trivial interest of our own species (our interest to enjoy a pleasant gustatory experience). This is unacceptable; if we think of ourselves as champions of equality, then we must extend this equality to our animal friends as well.

4. What Can We Do?

While the last two sections were much more philosophically grounded in what we *ought* to do regarding the treatment of animals, this one will be more focused on what we *can* do. However little that can be done at a societal level without organized efforts, I still believe it is important that we act as morally as we can. Here, we should consider the argument from causal impotence I first proposed in section two. In short, the argument rests upon the premise that, due to the size of the agribusiness industry, our purchasing habits can play no causal role in reducing the suffering of animals. However, I believe this is evidently false, as seen from countless historical examples. But to demonstrate this point, let us consider some numbers. In 1998, almost 8 billion chickens were slaughtered in the US, the vast majority of which were grown on factory farms. Suppose that there are 250 million chicken eaters in the US, and that, on average, each one of those chicken eaters consumes 25 chickens per year. It is obvious that if only one of those chicken eaters decided to become vegetarian, the industry would not respond. On the other hand, it is equally obvious that if every chicken eater decided to become vegetarian, the industry would collapse, thereby sparing billions of chickens from being tortured and killed. However, there must be some number of people far short of 250 million whose decision to go vegetarian would cause the industry to reduce the number of chickens being bred for consumption in factory farms. So, even if the industry does not respond to the individual's behavior, they must respond to the behavior of a large number of people. Suppose that this number is ten thousand, and for every ten thousand people who decide to become vegetarian, a quarter of a million fewer chickens are bred and killed every year. From this assumption, it appears that, by going vegetarian, you only have a one in ten thousand chance of making any difference to the lives of chickens. Does this probability render your action morally blameless? I do not think it should. Though the chance

that your behavior would be harmful is small, the harm that is risked by acting as such is enormous. We commonly accept that even small risks of great harms are unacceptable. Consider airplanes. The chance that any safety measures on the plane will be needed to save the lives of passengers in a given week is far smaller than one in ten thousand; in fact, it is closer to one in a million. Despite these odds, we would be outraged to discover if a commercial airline company had allowed for a plane to fly for a week without any functional emergency exits, oxygen masks, or lifejackets, given how irresponsible it would have been. So, even if the odds of being able to reduce the suffering of animals is small, given the amount of suffering that could be prevented, the argument from causal impotence does not in any way justify the continued consumption of meat.

Despite how herculean of a task it seems to create meaningful change in the face of such a large industry, I believe that it would be mistaken to be resigned to this fate. It is not a matter of apathy or cynicism, but *reflective impotence*. The fact that we believe that something is wrong, but we also believe that we cannot do anything about it, is not a passive observation of an existing state of affairs; it is a self-fulfilling prophecy. Moreover, not only is this pessimism self-defeating for any hopes for change, I believe it is plainly wrong. Many times throughout history, we have defeated forces just as powerful, if not more, as the agribusiness industry, and it always occurs in the same way: Ordinary people organize and form movements to demand change and do not give up until they have achieved it. Though this seems quite idealistic, it has happened several times in the past. As an example, consider the feminist movement of the 20th century. In 1962, there were no women in the US or British cabinet; women made up less than 4% of the US Senate; women were banned from getting a mortgage, opening a bank account, or even getting a job without written permission from their husbands; and there were no domestic violence shelters anywhere. In higher education, the alumni of some of the most prestigious schools in the nation pushed against coeducation in the 1970s, with one Dartmouth alumnus saying, "'For God's sake, for Dartmouth's sake, and for everyone's sake, keep the damned women out.'" On a banner hung from a dorm window at Dartmouth, a slogan read, "Better Dead Than Coed." At Princeton, an alumnus wrote, "What is all this nonsense about admitting women to Princeton? A good old-fashioned whore-house would be considerably more efficient, and much, much cheaper." Despite the challenges that women faced in this time, by 1972, all Ivy league universities, save Columbia, began to admit women. Looking at the state of the world now, the quality of life for women has vastly improved in almost all aspects; whereas my great-grandma was told to stop wasting time trying to get an education and start being obedient to men, my sister has attended and graduated from one of the most prestigious schools in the world with flying colors. This is a stunning achievement, and it came from one reason: an organized movement of ordinary women banded together and fought for equality, even when they faced systemic obstacles at every turn. If we have learned anything from the feminist movement or any progressive movement for change in the past, it is that massive and seemingly immovable forces in our society can be challenged by ordinary people. Though men had

controlled nearly everything in society, from the parliament to corporations to the police force, and had done so for as long as human civilization has existed, in the end, the power of ordinary people was able to induce meaningful change for every generation after them. It would have been very easy for women to say, at that moment, “Nothing can change. We should just give up and learn to live a life of subordination.” Such a thought process is hauntingly similar to the political nihilism that characterizes so many today. But the thing is, this pessimistic belief in one’s powerlessness is that it is *false*. Though it may be difficult to get a movement off the ground, anything worth fighting for will inevitably face immense resistance initially. As a historical example, when labor unions first began to campaign for weekends, the people involved in such campaigns were beaten by the police and their leaders were shot or hung. In comparison to these forces, the agribusiness industry we face today is far less challenging than the cliffs they had to climb. The youth of our current generation are often told by their elders that they are naive when campaigning for social change. However, I believe that the exact opposite is true. It is naive to think that ordinary citizens can have no causal influence on the world and that we should just leave the powerful to do whatever they want to do. There is nothing naive in thinking that organized democratic campaigning can change the world. Now, there are questions we must face, and we must decide: Do we value the equality of our animal friends? Do we want to minimize the amount of suffering in the world? Do we want to be good people? If we have answered yes to any of these questions, then we must work towards it as individuals now.

5. Conclusion

I believe that our current systematic oppression of animals will be viewed by the future as no less morally abhorrent than how we currently view slave owners in 19th-century America. This is perhaps a radical position to take, but so too was every serious progressive movement in the past until their truths were accepted as common sense. I cannot stress enough that the call for animal liberation, like the movement for the freedom of slaves or activism for acceptance of gay people, is inherently moral; if we wish to stand on the right side of history, I believe that this is a position we must adopt. In any case, if the arguments in this article have convinced you in any way to believe in the wrongness of consuming meat, then I urge you, at the very least, to reduce the amount of meat you are consuming in your diet. Even if you don’t think of it as much, I believe that, within all of us, we have the ability to change the world.